

[Return to Search](#)

Libyan politics

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Zuwaya made connections among these snippets and anecdotes, documents and poems. They were not a shapeless porridge of symbols, for at any rate some of them were consistently connected with others. Some were juxtaposed in permanent mutual evocation: owning the desert; taxing strangers; taxing Awjla and Jalu was one such set. Another was peace-making through marriage, death by homicide, defence of property (or failure to defend it). A third, resistance to the Italians and support of the Sanusiya, and death in battle (the fighters at Hawaria tied their legs, a band round shin and thigh, to be incapable of running away). So a conversation would start from one point, and one thing would lead to another. The clusters overlapped, and the regularity was not perfect, but enough to give shape and pattern to repeated conversations in Ajdabiya, Ajkharra, Kufra and Tazarbu over five years.

173
[Traditional History](#)

619
[Tribe And Nation](#)

814
[Humanistic Studies](#)

Perhaps the commonest phrase people used in their talk about the past was *al-hukuma al-'arabiya* (which can be translated as 'people's government' or 'Arab government'). And this, too, imposed a pattern by grouping incidents under a single heading. It was a category, a catch-phrase, a summation; and it also provided a mild but pleasing joke because it used 'government' to refer to its absence, and because the ' *arabi* ('people's government') of tradition contrasted with the *sha'bi* ('people's government') of the present regime, seen in this context to be the opposite of what real people's government ought to be. Zuwaya nearly always used 'Arab government' to compare their present unfavourably with the past, to sum up the virtues of a golden age: heroism and independence, autonomy, fraternal solidarities, an absence of hierarchy. The moral connotation was accentuated by the always at least implicit use of the term to contest, to resist contemporary claims of state. Other such terms,

173
[Traditional History](#)

619
[Tribe And Nation](#)

642
[Form And Rules Of Government](#)

for example *free*, as in 'then we were free', certainly had reference to the past, but carried direct contemporary reference: a man would say of another, 'he is a free  186 man', and mean that he took no orders from a superior; and a man (asked about his own occupation) might say with some pride that he was a 'free Zuwayi' (*zuwayi hurr*), and imply his condition was closer to the old days than that of most of those he saw around him. 'Free Zuwayi' in 1979 carried the message, 'of the old type'. Certain institutions carried the same message: lineage welfare payments, for instance, and the solemnities of threatening vengeance and exacting a settlement, were ' *adat* (customary), the way we have always done things, living reminders of a time when 'we did everything in this way'.

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